

The First 90 Days in the Trades

How to Get Hired at 18 (2026 Playbook)

The complete playbook for landing a paid apprenticeship, earning \$40K-\$100K+, and skipping \$100K+ in student debt — all before your friends finish their sophomore year.

12-Week

Action Plan

\$60K-\$100K+

Salary Potential

\$0

Student Debt

Why This Guide Exists

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THIS IS NOT YOUR GUIDANCE COUNSELOR'S ADVICE

Most 18-year-olds get the same advice: go to college, get a degree, figure out the rest later. That advice costs \$80,000–\$160,000 and leaves you with \$30,000–\$40,000 in debt before you earn your first real paycheck. Meanwhile, your classmate who started an electrician apprenticeship just hit the job site earning \$35/hour — with zero debt, full benefits, and a clear path to \$60K–\$80K within four years.

WHO THIS GUIDE IS FOR

- You're 16–24 and thinking about what comes after high school (or you already dropped out — no judgment).
- You're tired of school and want to earn while you learn, not pay to learn.
- You've heard trades pay well but don't know where to start or who to call.
- You want a step-by-step playbook, not vague career advice.
- You want to be earning \$40K–\$50K within your first year and \$60K–\$100K+ as a journey-level in 3–5 years.

WHAT YOU'LL GET IN THIS GUIDE

- A week-by-week, 12-week hiring timeline from zero experience to paid apprentice.
- Copy-paste resume and application templates built for trade employers.
- The real tools-to-buy list with prices — no hype, no filler.
- Money math: income vs. student debt scenarios using real site salary data.
- Safety basics, workplace rules, and day-one survival tips.
- A printable 90-day checklist you can pin on your wall.
- Myth-busting FAQ that kills the “you need college” narrative with facts.

The Opportunity Right Now

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WHY THE TIMING IS PERFECT (2026)

The Bureau of Labor Statistics projects 750,000+ open trade positions in the US. Baby-boom retirees are leaving the workforce faster than new tradespeople can replace them. That means employers are desperate for young, motivated workers — and they're offering signing bonuses, tuition reimbursement, and premium starting pay to get them.

SALARY SNAPSHOT (FROM THE TRADELIFT SITE)

These are the canonical journey-level salary bands from tradelift.surge.sh:

Electrician	\$60K-\$80K	4-5 yr apprenticeship
Plumber	\$55K-\$75K	4-5 yr apprenticeship
HVAC Technician	\$50K-\$70K	3-5 yr program
Welder	\$45K-\$70K	6-7 mo cert or 3-4 yr union
Carpenter	\$45K-\$65K	3-4 yr apprenticeship
Construction Manager	\$70K-\$100K	8-12 yr field path

THE BOTTOM LINE

Every dollar you spend on a guide is a dollar that has to prove its worth. This guide pays for itself the first time you nail a resume submission that gets you an interview. The content inside is what separates someone who “thinks about trades” from someone who’s hired and earning in 90 days. That’s the promise — and it’s why this guide exists at a price anyone can afford.

How Apprenticeships Work

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UNION vs. NON-UNION: THE TWO PATHS

Apprenticeships are paid, on-the-job training programs where you earn a wage while learning from a seasoned journey-level worker. There are two main routes:

UNION APPRENTICESHIP

- Run through a joint training fund (IBEW, UA, UBC, Ironworkers, etc.).
- Structured 3-5 year program with scheduled raises every 6-12 months.
- Start at 40-50% of journeyman scale; top out at 80-100% after graduation.
- Tuition is usually covered or heavily subsidized.
- Strong job placement — unions have contractor relationships built in.
- Drawback: waitlists and intake windows can be competitive.

NON-UNION (OPEN-SHOP / MERIT) APPRENTICESHIP

- Run through individual contractors, trade associations (ABC, IEC), or trade schools.
- May require tuition payment (\$5K-\$15K) before or during the program.
- Flexible hiring — many shops hire year-round, not just intake windows.
- Pay and structure vary by company; negotiate your terms.
- Drawback: fewer guaranteed job placements; you self-market.

SEALED PATHS & HIDDEN PIPELINES

Some trades have “sealed” apprenticeship pathways — meaning once you’re accepted into a registered program, your hours, credentials, and raises are locked into a national database. Your journey-level license travels with you across state lines. Always verify a program is registered with [apprenticeship.gov](https://www.apprenticeship.gov).

Weeks 1-4: Foundation

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WEEKS 1-2: RESEARCH & DECIDE

- Pick your top 2 trades (use the TradeLift quiz if you haven't yet).
- Compare union vs non-union routes for your top trades.
- Call 3 local contractors and ask: "Do you take apprentices, and when's your next intake?"
- Set a budget: tools, certification fees, transportation costs.
- Start a simple spreadsheet tracking every program you find.

WEEKS 3-4: GET CERTIFIED

- Earn your OSHA 10-Hour card online (a few days, ~\$25-\$40).
- Get First Aid/CPR certified (one-day course at Red Cross).
- For HVAC: pass EPA 608 Universal — legally required from day one.
- For welding: schedule your AWS D1.1 structural certification test.
- Update your resume with your new certifications immediately.

Weeks 5-8: Train & Network

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WEEKS 5-6: ENROLL & BUY

- Apply to a trade school or register for a pre-apprenticeship program.
- If union: call your local hall and get on the intake list.
- Buy your starter tool kit (see the tools list inside this guide).
- Start a trade journal — document everything you learn and build.

WEEKS 7-8: NETWORK & SHADOW

- Shadow a working tradesperson for a full day if you can arrange it.
- Join a local union hall or trade association (SkillsUSA, NCCER).
- Attend a trade job fair or career event — dress clean, bring resumes.
- Connect with 3+ working tradespeople on LinkedIn or in person.

YOUR STARTER TOOLS LIST

You don't need \$2,000 in tools before day one. Start with the basics. Prices are approximate and consistent with the TradeLift tools guide.

Multi-meter (electrical / HVAC)	\$25-\$60
Wire strippers (electrician)	\$15-\$30
Tape measure (25 ft, all trades)	\$10-\$25
Speed square (carpentry / general)	\$10-\$20
Pipe wrench set (plumbing / pipefitting)	\$30-\$60
Socket set + torque wrench (mechanic)	\$40-\$90
Welding hood + gloves (welding)	\$80-\$200
OSHA-rated hard hat + safety glasses	\$20-\$50
Work gloves (cut-resistant, all trades)	\$15-\$35
Utility knife + markers + notepad	\$10-\$20

Total starter kit: approximately \$255-\$590. Way less than one semester of college.

Weeks 9-12: Apply & Land It

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WEEKS 9-10: APPLICATION BLITZ

- Draft a one-page trade resume using the template on the next page.
- Apply to at least 5 apprenticeships or entry-level helper positions.
- Customize each application: mention the specific trade, your OSHA card, any certifications.
- Follow up with a phone call 5-7 days after submitting each application.

WEEKS 11-12: INTERVIEW & CLOSE

- Prep for the aptitude test (math, mechanical reasoning, reading comprehension).
- Practice your interview: firm handshake, eye contact, show your certifications.
- Ask smart questions: "What does a typical day look like?" / "What tools should I bring?"
- Follow up after every interview with a thank-you email.
- Accept the offer. Start earning. Start your career.

TRADE RESUME TEMPLATE (COPY-PASTE)

Trade employers want to see certifications, physical capability, and reliability — not a list of extracurriculars. Keep it to one page.

[YOUR NAME]

[Your City, State] · [Phone] · [Email]

OBJECTIVE

Motivated and reliable worker seeking an apprenticeship position as [TRADE].

OSHA 10-Hour certified. Eager to earn, learn, and contribute on day one.

CERTIFICATIONS

- OSHA 10-Hour Construction — [Date Earned]
- First Aid / CPR — [Date Earned]
- [EPA 608 / AWS D1.1 / other] — [Date Earned]

EXPERIENCE

[Most recent job or project] · [Dates]

- Describe hands-on tasks: lifting, tools, equipment, problem-solving.
- Highlight reliability: attendance record, punctuality, teamwork.

EDUCATION

[High School / GED] — [Year or “In Progress”]

[Trade school / pre-apprenticeship program, if applicable]

REFERENCES

Available upon request.

Money Math: Income vs. Debt

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COLLEGE vs. TRADES: THE 10-YEAR FINANCIAL COMPARISON

This is the math they never show you at career day. Let's compare two 18-year-olds: one goes to a 4-year university, the other starts a trade apprenticeship.

THE COLLEGE PATH

- 4-year university cost: \$80,000–\$160,000 (avg 4-year public university)
- Average student loan debt at graduation: \$30,000–\$40,000 (avg student loan debt at graduation)
- Average starting salary: \$35K–\$45K (avg college grad starting salary)
- Monthly student loan payment (standard 10-yr): ~\$280–\$400/mo
- Time to reach \$50K salary: 2–4 years after graduation (age 24–26)

THE TRADES PATH

- Trade school or pre-apprenticeship cost: \$5,000–\$15,000 (avg trade school / pre-apprenticeship)
- Student debt: \$0 (apprenticeships are paid training) (apprenticeships are paid from day one)
- Starting apprentice wage: ~\$35K–\$50K (40–50% of journeyman scale)
- Journey-level salary: Electrician \$60K–\$80K, Plumber \$55K–\$75K, Welder \$45K–\$70K
- HVAC \$50K–\$70K, Construction Mgr \$70K–\$100K

THE 10-YEAR BOTTOM LINE

After 10 years, the college grad may still be paying off debt while earning a modest salary. The tradesperson has been earning since age 18–19, carries zero debt, and has reached journey-level or higher. In many trades, the cumulative earnings are equal or higher — and every dollar earned is debt-free.

Safety Basics & Workplace Rules

OSHA 10-HOUR: WHAT YOU NEED TO KNOW

The OSHA 10-Hour Construction card is the universal entry credential for the trades. It covers the ten most common hazards on a job site. You can earn it online in a few days for \$25-\$40 through an OSHA-authorized provider.

DAY-ONE WORKPLACE RULES

- Always wear your PPE: hard hat, safety glasses, steel-toe boots, gloves, hi-vis vest.
- Never touch live wires or open panels unless you're trained and authorized.
- Get a Job Hazard Analysis (JHA) briefing before starting any new task.
- If you see a hazard, report it immediately — don't walk past it.
- Tool inspection: check your tools at the start of every shift.
- Stay hydrated. Heat illness kills more workers than any other cause on outdoor sites.
- Ask questions. The stupidest question on a job site is the one that causes an injury.
- Clock in and out exactly. Reliability is #1 in hiring and retention.

PERSONAL PROTECTIVE EQUIPMENT (PPE) ESSENTIALS

Hard hat (Type I or II, ANSI Z89.1)	\$15-\$30
Safety glasses (ANSI Z87.1+)	\$5-\$15
Steel-toe boots (ASTM F2413)	\$80-\$160
Work gloves (cut-resistant, Level 5)	\$15-\$35
Hi-vis vest (ANSI Class 2)	\$10-\$20
Hearing protection (foam plugs or muffs)	\$3-\$20

Printable 90-Day Checklist

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YOUR 90-DAY ACTION CHECKLIST

WEEKS 1-4: FOUNDATION

- ☐ Pick top 2 trades (use TradeLift quiz)
- ☐ Call 3 local contractors about apprenticeships
- ☐ Earn OSHA 10-Hour card
- ☐ Get First Aid / CPR certified
- ☐ Draft one-page trade resume
- ☐ Research union vs. non-union options
- ☐ Set a tools + certification budget

WEEKS 5-8: TRAIN & NETWORK

- ☐ Apply to trade school or pre-apprenticeship
- ☐ Get on union hall intake list (if applicable)
- ☐ Buy starter tool kit (\$255-\$590 total)
- ☐ Shadow a working tradesperson
- ☐ Join SkillsUSA, NCCER, or a local trade group
- ☐ Attend a job fair or career event
- ☐ Connect with 3+ tradespeople (in person or LinkedIn)

WEEKS 9-12: APPLY & LAND IT

- ☐ Apply to 5+ apprenticeships or helper positions
- ☐ Customize each resume for the specific trade
- ☐ Follow up by phone 5-7 days after each application
- ☐ Prep for aptitude test (math, reading, mechanical)
- ☐ Practice interview (handshake, eye contact, certs)
- ☐ Send thank-you email after every interview
- ☐ Accept an offer. Start earning.

MYTHS ABOUT TRADES — DESTROYED WITH FACTS

MYTH: “Trades are a fallback for people who can’t get into college.”

FACT: The trades ARE the smart choice. A plumber earning \$55K-\$75K with zero debt is financially ahead of most 25-year-old college grads drowning in \$40K of loans.

MYTH: “Trade work is just grunt labor.”

FACT: Modern trades require deep technical knowledge. Electricians read complex blueprints. HVAC techs diagnose computer-controlled systems. Pipefitters calculate pressure ratings.

MYTH: “There’s no career growth in trades.”

FACT: Journeyman → foreman → superintendent → construction manager (\$70K-\$100K+). Or go independent: own a plumbing or electrical shop and clear six figures.

MYTH: “Trades are only for men.”

FACT: The trades need more women and diverse candidates. Many unions and contractors actively recruit women. Pre-apprenticeship programs welcome everyone.

MYTH: “You have to pay for trade school.”

FACT: Most union apprenticeships are tuition-free. The employer and union fund your training. You earn a wage from day one while learning on the job.

MYTH: “Trade jobs will be automated away.”

FACT: You can’t robot a leaky pipe in a 1950s house. You can’t automate emergency HVAC diagnosis. Physical trades require judgment, dexterity, and problem-solving that AI can’t match.

What To Do Next

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YOUR NEXT STEP: TAKE THE QUIZ

Still not sure which trade fits you? Take the free 2-minute TradeLift quiz and get matched with the trade that fits your personality, strengths, and goals.

Take the Free Quiz

tradelift.surge.sh/quiz.html

MORE FREE RESOURCES

- 12 free career roadmaps (one per trade): tradelift.surge.sh
- Trade Career Fit Guide (PDF): download after taking the quiz
- Starter tools guide: tradelift.surge.sh/tools.html
- Getting started roadmap: tradelift.surge.sh/getting-started.html
- Blog: salary deep-dives, career advice, trade comparisons

CREDITS & DISCLAIMER

Salary data sourced from tradelift.surge.sh, which draws on BLS and industry figures. Individual earnings vary by location, experience, and certifications. This guide is for educational purposes and does not guarantee employment. TradeLift © 2026.

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A TradeLift Premium Guide

tradelift.surge.sh

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Built for the next generation of skilled tradespeople.